

Privacy, Confidentiality & Recordkeeping

Handling participant information safely and writing professional records

Suggested training type: Read + mini quiz Suggested pass mark: 80% Review/validity: 12 months recommended review cycle

Learning objectives

- Understand why disability and health information requires careful handling.
- Apply data minimisation, consent and need-to-know principles.
- Write factual, respectful and useful support records.
- Know what must never be stored or shared through personal channels.

1. Personal and sensitive information

Support workers may handle names, addresses, contact details, NDIS information, health information, routines, behaviour information, family details and other sensitive records. Treat this information as confidential and access it only when required for authorised work.

2. Collect and share only what is needed

- Use approved Opus Care systems and processes.
- Only collect information reasonably necessary for the support or business purpose.
- Do not send participant information to personal email accounts or personal cloud storage.
- Do not share participant information with friends, unrelated staff or other participants.
- Check consent and authority before sharing information, unless disclosure is required or authorised by law or necessary under an emergency/safeguarding process.

3. Good progress notes

A good record is timely, factual, relevant and respectful. Record what was observed, what support was provided, important participant preferences or outcomes, and any follow-up required. Avoid insults, assumptions, diagnosis outside your role, gossip, or emotionally loaded language.

4. Example

Poor: 'John was impossible again and refused to cooperate.' Better: 'John declined the planned community outing at 10:15 am and said he wanted to stay home. Options were discussed. John chose to prepare lunch and listen to music instead. No immediate safety concerns observed.'

5. Security basics

- Lock the device when unattended.
- Do not photograph documents or screens unless explicitly authorised for the work task.
- Never reuse or share passwords.

- Report lost devices, misdirected emails or suspected privacy breaches immediately.
- Use the CRM rather than informal messaging for information that needs to become part of the participant record.

Knowledge Check

Choose the best answer for each question. Suggested pass mark: 80%. This quiz checks understanding of the module; it does not replace supervised practical competency where that is required.

1. What is the best rule for collecting participant information?
 - A. Collect everything in case it is useful
 - B. Collect only information reasonably necessary for an authorised purpose
 - C. Keep copies on your personal phone
 - D. Ask other participants for details

2. Which progress note is better?
 - A. 'She was difficult and lazy'
 - B. A factual description of what happened, what support was provided and the outcome
 - C. A diagnosis made by the worker
 - D. A message containing gossip

3. Where should participant records be stored?
 - A. Personal email
 - B. Approved Opus Care systems
 - C. Personal photo gallery
 - D. Public notes app

4. What should a worker do after accidentally emailing participant information to the wrong person?
 - A. Delete their own copy and say nothing
 - B. Report the privacy/security incident promptly
 - C. Wait to see if anyone notices
 - D. Post a correction publicly

5. Who should receive participant information?
 - A. Anyone who asks
 - B. Only authorised people who need it for a legitimate purpose, subject to consent/law
 - C. Friends of workers
 - D. Other participants

Manager answer key is included in the accompanying quiz JSON file.

Source and reference notes

This Opus Care resource is an original internal training summary. It is based on current public guidance and does not reproduce third-party courses. Workers should use the linked official resources where specified.

- <https://www.oaic.gov.au/privacy/australian-privacy-principles/australian-privacy-principles-guidelines>
- <https://www.oaic.gov.au/privacy/australian-privacy-principles/australian-privacy-principles-quick-reference>
- <https://www.ndiscommission.gov.au/rules-and-standards/ndis-practice-standards/core-module-provider-governance-and-operational>
- <https://www.ndiscommission.gov.au/workforce/supervision-and-effective-communication/working-together-guide-workers>

Important: Internal completion does not create a nationally recognised qualification, professional licence, or practical competency. Opus Care should verify external qualifications and practical skills appropriate to each worker's role and the supports actually delivered.